

C3 Transparency Workshop

Pillar	Communication	Difficulty	Level 2
Time Required	45-55 minutes	Group Size	5-15
Mode	Team facilitation	Format	In-person or remote
Prerequisites	C1 (Communication Audit) recommended	CLOVER ERA Trigger	Information silo signals, reduced trust in leadership, misalignment of goals, one-way communication, erosion of accountability

Why This Works

THE NEUROSCIENCE

Information asymmetry triggers the brain's threat detection system. When people sense that information is being withheld (even unintentionally), the amygdala interprets this as a social threat: 'What don't I know? Am I being excluded? Is something happening that affects me?' This drives cortisol and suspicion, eroding trust even when no deception exists.

Transparency reverses this. When information flows openly, cortisol drops and oxytocin rises. The brain shifts from threat-scanning to collaborative processing. Critically, the brain responds to the act of sharing as much as the content: the signal 'I trust you with this information' is itself a trust-building mechanism.

The Exercise

Phase 1: Anonymous Concern Collection (8 minutes)

WHAT TO SAY

"I want to understand where transparency breaks down on this team. Not in the organisation at large. Here. Between us. Write down one thing you feel you don't have enough information about, or one area where you think information isn't flowing the way it should. No names. Just the gap."

Collect anonymously (cards shuffled, or Mentimeter). Read each one aloud. Group into themes on the flipchart.

Phase 2: Categorise the Gaps (10 minutes)

For each theme, the team categorises:

- "I can share this now" (information the manager has and can provide immediately)

- "I can share this with context" (information that exists but needs framing or timing)
- "I genuinely don't have this" (information the manager also lacks)
- "I can't share this and here's why" (confidential or premature information with a transparent explanation of why it can't be shared)

FACILITATION NOTE

The fourth category is critical. "I can't tell you" with no explanation destroys trust. "I can't share details about this yet because negotiations are ongoing, but I will update you by [date]" builds it. Transparency is not about sharing everything. It is about being honest about what you can and cannot share, and why.

Phase 3: Manager Transparency Commitment (10 minutes)

For each gap in the first two categories, the manager makes a specific commitment:

- What information will be shared
- When it will be shared
- Through which channel

WHAT TO SAY

"Here's what I'm committing to based on what I've heard today. [Specific commitments.] And here's what I'm asking from you: if you feel a transparency gap forming, raise it. Don't wait for another exercise. A quick 'I feel like I'm missing context on X' in our team chat is enough."

Phase 4: Team-to-Team Transparency (10 minutes)

Transparency is not just manager-to-team. Team members withhold information from each other too: assumptions about who needs to know what, protectiveness over their domain, not sharing context that seems obvious to them.

WHAT TO SAY

"Now turn the lens on ourselves. Where do we as a team fail to share information with each other? Where do you hold information because you assume others already know, or because you don't think it's relevant to them?"

Capture commitments from team members to each other. These are peer agreements, not management directives.

Facilitation Notes

Situation	Response
A concern targets the manager directly ("You don't tell us what's going	Do not get defensive. "That's fair feedback. Let me respond to it directly. [Honest response about what you can and will change.] If I'm falling back into old patterns, I need you to tell me."

on")	
Concerns surface about organisational-level transparency that the manager cannot fix	Acknowledge the limit: "I hear this, and I share some of this frustration. What I can control is transparency within our team. For the organisational level, I'll advocate upward, but I want to be honest that I can't guarantee a change there."

Signs This Is Working

Timeframe	What to Look For
During the session	Concerns are specific, not vague The manager's honest responses land (visible relief or engagement) Team-to-team transparency gaps surface that hadn't been discussed before
Within 2-4 weeks	The manager delivers on commitments made in the session A team member proactively shares context they would previously have withheld Someone uses the agreed language: "I feel like I'm missing context on..."
CLOVER ERA data (4-6 weeks)	Communication and trust scores improve Information silo signals decrease Qualitative data references openness or transparency

Cross-Pillar Connections

Worksheet	Connection	Direction
C1: Communication Audit	C1 maps channels; C3 addresses what flows through them. C1 is structural; C3 is about content and trust.	Run C1 before C3
V1: Vulnerability Circle	Transparency requires vulnerability from the manager. V1 builds the manager's comfort with openness.	Run V1 before or alongside C3
E8 (merged): Trust Through Leadership	Trust and transparency are inseparable. C3 is the communication expression of trust-building.	Complementary